UCUG3801: Social Inequality and Social Mobility

Group Poster Assessment:

Liede: Reading Mobility and Inequality in Place

2026/27 Fall



Figure 1: Map showing Liede before Urban Regeneration.



Figure 2: Map showing the current night view of Liede.

Assessment Overview

In groups of 3–5 students, you will produce a research poster based on your field visit to Liede, Guangzhou. Your poster should use **sociological imagination** to connect everyday observations with wider social structures, including:

- urban development and housing;
- migration and hukou;
- gender and age;
- occupations and the service economy;
- social class and inequality;
- access to food, services, and public space;
- opportunities for social mobility.

The purpose is not simply to describe what you saw. You should explain **how personal experiences and everyday community life may be shaped by larger economic, political, historical, and social forces**.

Student Instructions

1. Group Composition

- Group members should participate in field observation, research and analysis, poster production, and presentation or discussion.
- Each student must submit a brief individual contribution statement.

2. Research Question

Your group must formulate one clear research question. The question should connect the community to inequality, social class, or social mobility.

Possible examples include:

- How do housing conditions and local prices reflect the change of social inequality in this community over time?
- How does the organization of public space shape the everyday lives of different social groups?
- What evidence of social stratification can be observed in local occupations, housing, and consumption?

- How might migrant and non-migrant residents experience the community differently? (Have your definition of migrant or even outsiders - e.g., Liede locals and non-Liede Cantonese)
- What kinds of mobility opportunities and obstacles has urban renewal brought to locals and migrants, respectively??
- How does urban redevelopment affect residents' daily lives and access to services?

Your question should be analytical rather than merely descriptive.

Weak: What do people do in the community?

Stronger: How does the local service economy reveal differences in class position and economic opportunity?

3. Evidence Collection

Your poster should draw on at least three types of evidence.

A. Systematic Observation

Record observations about:

- housing type, density, maintenance, and redevelopment;
- shops, restaurants, markets, and public services;
- street activity and use of public space;
- visible occupations and forms of work;
- age and gender patterns at particular times and locations;
- signs of wealth, deprivation, or uneven development;
- accessibility of services, transport, and amenities.

Avoid making claims based on one person or one brief encounter. Where possible, observe the same type of location at more than one time or in more than one area.

B. Price or Environmental Audit

Collect comparable information, such as:

- prices of several common meals or food items;
- rental advertisements, where publicly displayed;

- prices of everyday services;
- transport costs or travel time;
- availability of public facilities;
- condition and size of housing or commercial premises.

Explain how the items were selected and why the comparison is meaningful.

C. Background Research

Use reliable sources to research the history and development of the communities. Sources may include:

- academic publications;
- government statistics;
- official planning documents;
- reputable news reports;
- local historical materials;
- urban studies and sociological research.

Your poster should include at least four credible sources, including at least two academic or official sources.

D. Optional Short Conversations

If appropriate, you may conduct brief informal conversations. You must:

- explain who you are and why you are collecting information;
- ask for permission before taking notes or recording;
- avoid sensitive or intrusive questions;
- do not pressure anyone to participate;
- anonymize all responses;
- do not record names, phone numbers, addresses, or other identifying information.

Conversations are optional. Students will not be disadvantaged for choosing not to interview anyone.

Important Ethical Guidance

Do Not Infer Personal Identity from Appearance

Students should not claim that someone is a migrant, wealthy, poor, or from a particular social class based only on:

- clothing;
- accent or language;
- skin color;
- age;
- gender presentation;
- occupation guessed from appearance;
- physical appearance or behavior.

Instead, use cautious language such as:

- "We observed . . . "
- "At approximately 3 p.m., we counted . . . "
- "This advertisement stated . . . "
- "A participant who agreed to speak with us reported . . . "
- "These observations may suggest . . . , although they cannot establish . . . "

The purpose is to analyze **social patterns and structures**, not to label individuals.

Privacy and Photography

- Do not photograph identifiable people without consent.
- Do not photograph children.
- Do not enter private buildings or residential areas without permission.
- Do not publish identifiable faces, names, addresses, or private information.
- If photographs are used, they should focus on buildings, signs, streets, or public infrastructure and should not expose individuals.

Suggested Poster Structure

1. Title and Research Question

The title should be specific and analytical.

Include:

- group members;
- course code;
- fieldwork date;
- research question.

2. Community Background

Briefly explain:

- the location and history Liede;
- major changes in land use or population;
- relevant economic or policy developments;
- why Liede is useful for studying inequality or mobility.

3. Concepts and Theoretical Framework

Define and apply at least two sociological concepts, such as:

- social stratification;
- social class;
- social mobility;
- migration;
- precarity;
- gendered division of labor;
- spatial inequality;
- social reproduction.

Do not simply list definitions. Explain how the concepts help interpret your evidence.

4. Methods and Evidence

Briefly state:

- where and when you observed;
- how long observations lasted;
- what locations you selected;
- what you counted or compared;
- whether you conducted conversations;
- how you protected privacy;
- the limitations of your method.

Present your main findings using:

- photographs, where ethically appropriate;
- maps;
- diagrams;
- tables;
- charts;
- observation notes;
- price comparisons;
- short anonymized quotations.

At least one visual should compare the two communities.

5. Sociological Analysis

This is the most important section. Explain:

- what social patterns are visible;
- which groups may benefit from or be disadvantaged by local arrangements;
- how housing, work, prices, services, or public space are related;
- how individual experiences may be connected to wider structures;
- what the evidence suggests about social mobility;

- whether the two communities reveal different forms of inequality.

Use cautious, evidence-based claims. A poster should distinguish clearly between:

1. what we observed;
2. what we think it may mean;
3. what wider research helps us understand.

6. Reflexivity and Limitations

Discuss at least three limitations, such as:

- observations were conducted only at one or two points in time;
- people's social class or migration status cannot be reliably identified from appearance;
- the sample was not representative;
- students may have interpreted behavior through their own social and cultural assumptions;
- prices may vary by shop, time, or product quality;
- public observations do not reveal private experiences;
- the presence of researchers may have influenced behavior.

Explain how these limitations affect your conclusions.

7. Conclusion

Answer your research question directly. Summarize:

- the most important finding;
- what the field visit reveals about inequality or mobility;
- one broader sociological implication;
- one question for further research.

8. References

Use a consistent referencing style, such as APA, Harvard, or Chicago.

Poster Format

- Digital submission: Image, e.g., PDF or JPEG format.
- Recommended size proportion: 16:9, horizontal.
- Use readable fonts and clear headings.
- Avoid overcrowding the poster with text.
- All charts, photographs, maps, and quotations must have captions.
- All external data and images must be referenced.

Group Poster Submission and Individual Short Summary Submission

Each group should submit their poster in e-form before 2 pm one day before the guest lecture.

Each group will evaluate other groups' posters and present its own to explain its ideas and analysis.

Each group should:

1. evaluate other groups' posters;
2. answer questions from classmates, guest lecturers, or the instructor;
3. each member should submit a 150–200 word contribution statement and an evaluation of the contribution of your group mates.

Assessment Rubric

Table 1: Group Poster Assessment Rubric

Criterion	Marks	Excellent Performance
Research question and focus	10	Clear, focused, and sociologically relevant question that guides the whole poster. [Most interesting question award]
Use of sociological concepts and literature	15	Uses at least two relevant concepts accurately and applies credible academic or official sources effectively.
Quality and variety of evidence	20	Uses systematic observations, comparisons, visuals, and/or ethically collected conversations. Evidence is relevant and well documented. [Most evidence-based award]
Analysis of inequality and social mobility	20	Provides nuanced analysis of class, gender, migration, housing, work, access, or mobility. Avoids unsupported generalizations.
Reflexivity, ethics, and limitations	10	Clearly recognizes ethical issues, positionality, uncertainty, and methodological limitations.
Organization and visual communication	10	Poster is coherent, readable, well designed, and easy to follow. [Best looking award]
Presentation and group participation	15	Clear oral explanation; all members participate; questions are answered thoughtfully.
Total	**100**	

Individual Contribution and Peer Evaluation

To ensure fair group assessment, each student should submit a 150–200 word contribution statement explaining:

- their responsibilities;
- the work they completed;
- what they learned;
- one way the group collaborated;
- one difficulty the group encountered.

Students may also complete a confidential peer-evaluation form. If there is clear evidence of unequal participation, individual marks may be adjusted.

Suggested Fieldwork Recording Template

Table 2: Fieldwork Recording Template

Time and location	**Observation**	**Possible sociological significance**	**Evidence/limitations**
10:00 p.m., street market	Many small food stalls and frequent customer turnover.	May indicate a low-cost service economy and high pedestrian activity.	Observation made on one weekend morning.
11:30 p.m., residential lane	High-rise buildings, gated entrances, and car-free walking lanes.	May reflect differences in housing quality or redevelopment pressure.	No access to private interiors.
12:00 p.m., restaurant area	Meal prices were higher at the shopping mall than at the market.	May indicate differences in consumption environments.	Items were not perfectly identical.

This format encourages students to separate **description from interpretation**, which is central to sociological analysis.